THE COMPLETE PLAYBOOK

Design in Claude Code

Not Canva. Not Figma.
The AI-native design workflow that changes everything.

SPECIAL THANKS TO

Charlie Hills

Author of the original article on MarTech AI.
Thank you for sharing this workflow with the world.

BASED ON THE ARTICLE FROM MARTECH AI NEWSLETTER

INTRODUCTION

Why This Playbook Exists

AI design is moving from accepting outputs to owning them. Six months ago, AI-generated visuals meant "type a prompt and hope for the best." That was it. One option. Today, there are three distinct levels of AI design maturity, and most people never make it past the first one.

The gap between Level 1 and Level 3 is where the real advantage lives. Every "I made this with AI" post on LinkedIn skips the setup. The generation takes 30 seconds. The system behind it took days to build. This playbook walks you through every level, every trade-off, and the exact approach to get pixel-perfect, on-brand visuals without a design degree.

> **The Short Version:** You move from typing a prompt and getting what you get (Gemini), to having structured but limited control (Claude Chat), to owning every pixel through code-generated design (Claude Code).

The Three Levels at a Glance

Gemini	Claude Chat	Claude Code
LEVEL 1	LEVEL 2	LEVEL 3
Quick image generation	HTML/CSS code output	Full file ownership
No brand control	Some brand control	Total brand control
Not editable	Partially editable	Every pixel editable
Best for one-off posts	High token usage	Compound results

You do not need to know how to code. The entire system is built through conversational language. You talk to Claude Code the way you would brief a human designer, and it adjusts. Now let us break down each level in detail.

LEVEL 1

Gemini

Type a prompt. Get an image. Post it. Done.

This is where most people start. And honestly, where most people stop. You describe what you want, Gemini builds it. A prompt like "Create an infographic showing 5 ways to use AI for email marketing. Handwritten notebook style, blue and white colour scheme" gives you a visual in thirty seconds.

For single-use infographics and social posts, this is more than enough. The handwritten style was a total pattern interrupt on LinkedIn when it first appeared. But then everybody started doing it. Now it has gone from a pattern interrupt to a pattern. They all look the same.

> **The Core Limitation:** You get what you get. If the output is 90% right but the headline font is wrong or the spacing feels off, your only option is to regenerate and hope. The generate-squint-regenerate-squint-settle dance is real.

What Gemini Does Well

- Fast turnaround for single-use visuals and social posts
- More creative and better for illustrations than text-based approaches
- Accessible to anyone with no technical setup required
- Great for exploring visual concepts and brainstorming ideas
- Works well when you do not need output to match existing brand assets

What Gemini Cannot Do

- No brand control - each output is a standalone creation
- No editability - you cannot tweak individual elements after generation
- No memory - no brand consistency between sessions
- No ownership - the output is a flat image with no source file

> "I have posted dozens of Gemini-generated infographics on LinkedIn. They perform. But every single one is a standalone creation with no memory or brand consistency between sessions."
>
> - Charlie Hills

BEST FOR

Quick one-off visuals where you do not need brand consistency and are happy with the output as-is.

LEVEL 2

Claude Chat

HTML/CSS in the chat interface. More control, but at a cost.

Instead of generating a flat image like Gemini, Claude writes the visual as HTML and CSS code. You do this in Claude's chat interface or Cowork too. When you prompt Claude with something like "create an HTML CSS infographic on Claude's AI ecosystem," it generates a decent visual. Not bad for a first attempt.

The output is more structured than Gemini, which is a genuine step forward. But Gemini is more creative and better for illustrations. This is a trade-off, not an upgrade. You are swapping visual creativity for layout control.

> The problems: it is not optimised for social media dimensions (1080 x 1350), it is not on brand, and the iteration process burns through your usage incredibly fast. Even on the 10x Max plan, limits get hit regularly.

How It Works in Practice

You upload your brand kit, Claude rewrites the code to match your colours and typography. But every change is another generation. Another chunk of your usage gone. The output looks better than Gemini, but the cost per infographic is high and the process is slow. Each iteration requires a full regeneration.

The Trade-offs

- **More structured layouts** than Gemini, but less creative freedom
- **Brand control improves** when you upload your brand kit
- **Token cost per output is high** – iteration burns through Claude usage fast
- **The interface is different** from Claude Code, but the workflow is similar
- **Cowork burns through usage** even faster doing the same work

> "The output is more structured than Gemini, but Gemini is more creative and better for illustrations. This is a trade-off, not an upgrade. You are swapping visual creativity for layout control."
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> – Charlie Hills

BEST FOR

Structured layouts that need more control than Gemini but you are not ready for the full Claude Code setup.

LEVEL 3

Claude Code

Code-generated design. Full control. Full ownership. This is where things get interesting.

Instead of describing an image and hoping for the best, you give Claude Code your brand rules, your hex colours, your font preferences, and your layout specifications. It generates the visual as code. You get a file you own. Every pixel is editable.

Claude Code enters plan mode. It picks the right template, proposes a layout, and you align on the brief before it writes a single line of code. You approve. It generates an HTML file, converts it to a PNG, and stores it in your local files. The whole process runs through conversation.

109	11	95+
VERSIONS OF ONE INFOGRAPHIC TO GET IT RIGHT	SUBFOLDERS IN THE GENERATOR SYSTEM	QUALITY SCORE TARGET PER OUTPUT

> **Key Insight:** You do not need to know how to code. The entire infographic generator system was built through conversational language in Claude Code. Hours of conversation until the system was production-ready. If your brand does not exist as a documented system, the output looks generic. The AI has nothing to work with except defaults.

Why Claude Code Wins

- **Full ownership:** You get actual files, not flat images. Every element is editable.
- **Brand consistency:** Your brand kit is baked into the system. Every output follows the same rules.
- **Compound results:** Each new piece reinforces the one before it. The system learns from what you have already built.
- **Conversation-based:** You talk to it like a designer. Show it what good looks like. Show it what bad looks like. It adjusts.
- **Cost-efficient at scale:** Claude Code uses significantly less usage than Claude Chat for the same work at volume.

BEST FOR

Those with a defined brand who want fully editable visuals and are willing to invest the setup time for compound returns.

THE SYSTEM

How to Build It

The 9-step process behind Claude Code design generation.

Before writing a single prompt, you need your colours, your typography rules, and your spacing logic documented. If you do not have yours documented, start there. Everything else depends on it. Here is the proven setup process.

1 **Document Your Brand Rules**

Define your hex colours, typography choices, spacing logic, and canvas size. This is the foundation. Without it, every output defaults to generic.

2 **Install Your Brand Kit as a Skill**

Load your brand rules into Claude Code as a SKILL.md file. This becomes the system's persistent memory for design decisions across every session.

3 **Set Up Your CLAUDE.md File**

Create the core configuration file that tells Claude Code how to behave. Include your project structure, preferred templates, and output specifications.

4 **Build Your Folder Architecture**

Create subfolders for templates, reference files, QA scripts, and assets. In the assets folder, store your headshot, tool logos, and brand imagery for quick access.

5 **Create HTML Templates**

Build reusable HTML/CSS template structures for infographics and carousels. These become the starting point for every generation, saving enormous iteration time.

6 **Add Reference Files**

Include examples of good and bad designs, edge case examples, and brand guidelines. Claude Code uses these to calibrate its output quality against your standards.

7 **Build QA Sub-Agents**

Set up automated review workflows that check every output against your design guidelines before you even look at it. Target a quality score of 95+ out of 100.

8 **Generate and Iterate**

Run your first generation. Show Claude what is right and wrong. Every generation teaches the system something. The templates, references, and review workflows all refine from here.

9

Refine and Scale

Update templates, tweak design guidelines, and refine the CLAUDE.md file. The results compound as you update your system. Each output makes the next one faster and better.

DEEP DIVE

Iteration and Quality

The generation takes 30 seconds. The system behind it takes days. Here is what nobody tells you.

AI does not get it right on the first generation. Or the fifth. One infographic took over 109 versions before it was publishable. To be fair, not all of them take this long. The "Meet Your Claude Code Marketing Team" piece was 6 versions in about 45 minutes. But the reality is that iteration is where the time goes.

The whole process runs through conversation. You show Claude Code what good looks like. You show it what bad looks like. You talk to it the way you would brief a designer, and it adjusts. The templates, the reference files, the review workflows. All of this exists because the raw output from a single prompt is never good enough to post.

> The consistency compounds. Each new piece reinforces the one before it. Your audience starts to recognise your style before they read the content. That is the power of a system over a standalone generation.

The QA Workflow

Build QA sub-agents to review every output against your design guidelines before you even look at it. Claude continuously refines until the output scores 95+ out of 100 based on all the instructions, references, and critiques you have given it. Without this, you are sitting there iterating for hours manually.

Real Results from Claude Code

480K	171K	123K
IMPRESSIONS FROM 3 "UGLY" GRAPHICS	IMPRESSIONS ON ONE CAROUSEL POST	IMPRESSIONS ON ONE INFOGRAPHIC POST

Both posts used infographic visuals generated entirely through code. The whole space is moving from accepting what AI gives you to owning it. Claude Code is proof the system works. And once the system is built, generating new visuals takes thirty seconds with zero iterations.

BEYOND INFOGRAPHICS

Carousels and Scaling

This works for carousels too. Your brand kit, templates, and QA sub-agents all carry over.

Once you have your Claude Code system set up for infographics, carousels are the natural next step. Your brand kit, templates, and QA sub-agents all carry over from infographics. The process is identical: you type "create a carousel on [topic]" and Claude Code generates each slide as a PNG and renders the full carousel as a PDF.

This is where the compound effect really kicks in. The first carousel from the same system took 30 seconds with no iterations or changes. Compare that to the 109 versions of the first infographic. The system had already learned what good looks like.

What Makes Claude Code Different at Scale

- **Cowork burns through usage** doing the same work. Claude Code is significantly more efficient for volume generation.
- **The system gets better** because it learns from what you have already built. Templates improve, QA scoring becomes more accurate, and the output quality rises with every piece.
- **You edit everything** after generation, not by changing code, but through a visual editor. The source files are always there if you need to go deeper.
- **Brand recognition compounds** over time. Your audience starts to recognise the style before they read the content.

> "I bake the brand rules directly into the system, so every infographic follows the same colour palette, typography, and spacing logic. My audience now recognises the style before they read the content."
>
> – Charlie Hills

The Reality Check

Most people will never do the Level 3 work. The setup takes hours. But Level 3 has a real cost: setup. And the setup is not the hard part. The iteration is where the time goes. But once the system is running, every new piece takes 30 seconds. That is the investment thesis.

Ready to Build Your System?

CLAUDE CODE DESIGN PLAYBOOK

You could copy the principles from this playbook into Claude and start building your own setup right now. The approach works. You have enough to go test it yourself.

QUICK REFERENCE

Your Cheatsheet

Everything you need to remember, on one page. Pin this somewhere visible.

LEVEL 1 - GEMINI

Quick and Easy

Prompt-based image generation. Fast, creative, no setup required. Use when you need a quick visual for a single post and do not need brand consistency. Output is a flat image with no editability. Best for brainstorming and one-off social posts.

LEVEL 2 - CLAUDE CHAT

Structured Control

HTML/CSS code generation through Claude's chat interface. More structured layouts than Gemini with partial brand control through brand kit uploads. Higher token cost per output. Use when you want structured layouts but are not ready for Claude Code's full setup.

LEVEL 3 - CLAUDE CODE

Full Ownership

Code-generated design with complete brand control. Install brand kit as a skill, build template systems, set up QA sub-agents, and generate pixel-perfect visuals through conversation. Every output is an editable file. Compound results over time. Use when you have a defined brand and want production-quality visuals at scale.

The 9-Step Setup (Summary)

1. **Document brand rules (colours, typography, spacing)**
2. **Install brand kit as SKILL.md**
3. **Set up CLAUDE.md configuration**
4. **Build folder architecture (templates, assets, QA)**
5. **Create HTML/CSS templates**

6. **Add reference files (good and bad examples)**

7. Build QA sub-agents (target 95+ score)
8. Generate, iterate, and teach the system
9. Refine templates and scale output

Key Principles

- **Document first, prompt second.** No brand documentation means generic output.
- **Every generation teaches the system.** The compound effect is the real power.
- **Quality over speed in setup.** 109 versions of one infographic is normal.
- **You do not need to code.** Everything is built through conversation.
- **The gap between Level 1 and 3 is the competitive advantage.**